

22
PLAYERS, POWER AND FRATRICIDE

NOT TOO long ago, there used to be an unwritten policy called 'Player Power' used in the Pakistani dressing room. The senior players were not just experienced cricketers and expected to lead the team in the field. Their views were also taken into account for policy decisions. What they recommended, the board largely accepted. They were on the inside, and their learnings mattered.

This wasn't always a good approach and personal biases clouded the judgement of senior players from time to time. Still, it worked well because that's the way cricket was always played and the team managed in Pakistan. In fact, Player Power exists as a formal or informal policy in other cricket boards and teams too. Veteran players have their finger on the pulse of the team and its capacity, and are always consulted before big steps are taken. They are always looped in before making major decisions.

But something, somewhere has gone wrong within the PCB. Somewhat recently, the board decided that it liked the 'Yes, sir' type of players, who would go along with whatever the board wanted. Thus, Player Power, for long the centre of gravity of the national team, ended, and the system changed. This really damaged our cricket. The seniors, who are the connect between the board and the players, have no input in the system anymore. This has harmed the efficiency of the team.

Here's a case study: In 2010–11, we had a very, very good team that was beginning to gel and had an excellent understanding of each other. But it didn't happen overnight. At least, not until issues between the coach Waqar Younis and me, the captain, had been resolved.

There was a back story to it. Soon after the spot-fixing scandal, there was a rebellion of sorts within the team against me. I was blamed for getting Butt, Asif and Amir caught. They wanted to push me to the side. I didn't relent. I hardened up. I had the full backing of the board and Ijaz Butt, the chairman. With his support, I started consolidating the team too, and even delivered wins in the series in the West Indies. But this was a sensitive, critical juncture, and I needed all